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FREE WHITE PAPER | NOVEMBER 2026 | 12 MINUTE READ

AR8 contracts are due in March 2027. Three clocks start that day.

Procurement without the pauses: supplier choice, contracts and the lender pack, for energy developers onshore and offshore

18 months to the CfD spend milestone. 90 days to accept a grid offer. Up to 4 years for a large transformer. On a 60 MW solar project, each month of pause pushes back about £0.31m of revenue.

The working is on page 2. How to find your own pauses in an afternoon is on page 4.

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Not legal, regulatory or investment advice. Facts checked 31 October 2026; AR8 dates after 19 November are indicative.

00 THE ANSWER FIRST

Most procurement time is lost between gates. Start before you win.

For CEOs and procurement, commercial and development leads at energy developers. AR8 contracts are indicatively signed 4 to 17 March 2027.[8] The CfD then gives you 18 months to show spend of at least 10% of pre-commissioning costs.[1] Large transformers can take up to 4 years.[3]

EACH MONTH OF PAUSE

about £0.31m

of revenue pushed back (£3.77m a year ÷ 12), 60 MW solar

IN TODAY'S MONEY

about £0.22m

lost for each month the start date slips

Example project: 60 MW solar, 11% capacity factor (assumption)	**57,816 MWh a year**
Revenue at the AR7 solar price: 57,816 × £65.23[7]	**about £3.77m a year**
Value of 20 years of revenue today, at 7% (assumption): £3.77m × 10.594	**about £39.9m**
One month later: £39.9m × (1 − $1/1.07^{1/12}$)	**about £0.22m lost**
Most likely: two months of pauses before commissioning (assumption)	**about £0.45m lost**
Downside: the 18-month milestone is missed and the contract is at risk	**up to £39.9m at stake**

Worked example: 60 MW solar, 11% capacity factor, 20-year contract, 7% discount rate, two months of pauses, AR7 solar clearing price of £65.23/MWh in 2024 prices. All but the price are Ignis assumptions. Method on page 13.

THREE FINDINGS

1. **The pauses sit between gates.** Packages are redrawn and questions asked twice. The lender pack is rebuilt at the end. The milestones keep running.
2. **Procurement now feeds the bid.** Under EU rules, the ability to deliver on time is a qualification test for renewables auctions. Supplier evidence goes into the round itself.[6]
3. **Costs can outrun a project after award.** Vattenfall stopped Norfolk Boreas in 2023, citing cost rises of up to 40%. Ørsted stopped Hornsea 4 in its current form in May 2025.[4,5]

DECIDE BEFORE AR8 SEALED BIDS CLOSE (INDICATIVELY 9 DECEMBER 2026)

How much to spend on suppliers before award, per project. Who owns one date register for the grid date, CfD milestone and supplier programmes.

Yorik Tisseau, Founder, Ignis Leadership | November 2026 | 12 minute read | Inside: why now (p3), where procurement waits (p4 to p5), what to fix (p6 to p9), self-check (p11), the cost of waiting (p12), sources (p13)

01 WHY NOW

Three clocks start at award, and none waits for a tender pack

So what: the contract, grid and supply chain clocks start together at award. Your procurement must already be moving.

18 months

After signing a UK CfD, the generator must show spend of at least 10% of pre-commissioning costs, or the project commitments.[1]

90 days

To accept a GB transmission connection offer once it arrives.[2]

Up to 4 years

To secure large power transformers. Cables take two to three years, and lead times have almost doubled since 2021.[3]

When costs outrun the project

In July 2023 Vattenfall stopped developing Norfolk Boreas in its current form, citing cost increases of up to 40%.[4]

On 7 May 2025 Ørsted stopped Hornsea 4 in its current form after winning a CfD in 2024, pointing to higher supply chain costs, higher interest rates and greater execution risk.[5]

Neither was a paperwork problem. Both show, in the Ignis view, how little room there is between award and investment decision.

Procurement now feeds the bid

Under the EU Net-Zero Industry Act, the ability to deliver on time is a test to qualify for renewables auctions, and resilience can be scored.[6] Supplier evidence is no longer only for lenders. It goes into the round itself.

Onshore and offshore alike: the packages differ in size and number. Both lose the same weeks between gates.

THE IGNIS VIEW

Policy, grid, the supply chain and lenders each move on their own calendar, and projects stall in the gaps between them. The industry needs coordination from policy and regulation through to the industrial plan. Inside the developer the same rule applies: start procurement before the round is won, and keep every gate ready before the last one closes.



02 WHERE PROCUREMENT WAITS

Seven gates, and the time lost between them

So what: the gates are not the problem. The gaps are, where work waits for a decision or is redone.

THE SAME SEVEN GATES, RUN TWO WAYS

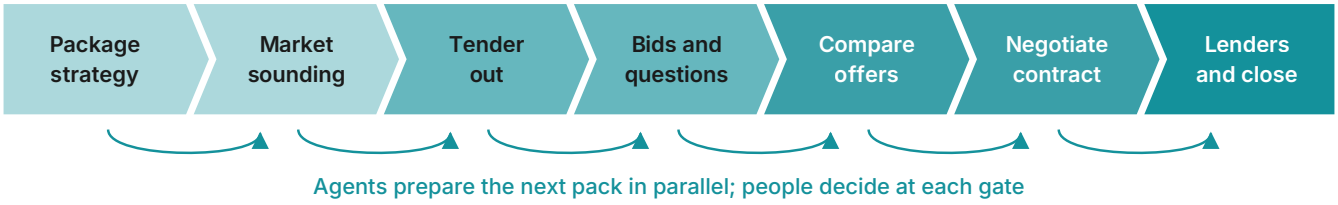
TODAY: EACH GATE WAITS FOR THE LAST ONE TO FINISH



1. Design not frozen, so packages are redrawn
2. Scope rewritten for the tender documents
3. The same questions asked by every bidder
4. Offers arrive in different shapes and scopes
5. The model and the draft contract drift apart
6. Due diligence starts from a blank folder

Pauses and gaps: work stops, or is redone, while the next gate gets ready.

WITH ONE RECORD AND AGENTS: THE NEXT GATE IS READY BEFORE THIS ONE CLOSES



One project record underneath every gate

Scope, packages, offers, clarifications, model inputs, contract terms and lender answers, versioned and owned

Source: Ignis framework, not data.

What stays the same

The gates, the decisions and the people who take them. Shortlist, preferred bidder, risk allocation and signature stay with your team and your board.

What changes

The next pack is drafted while this gate is decided. Nothing is retyped. A change is approved once and reaches every document that uses it.

Find your own pauses in an afternoon

Take one package you closed last year. Put the date each gate opened and closed on one line. The gaps between them are your pauses. For the two longest, ask what the team was waiting for, and whether it had to wait.



02 EARLY PROCUREMENT, BEFORE GATE 1

Procurement starts before the round is won

So what: early supplier work is money at risk, but the bid needs it. Do it once, on one record, and it becomes your first tender pack.

1 Sound the market

A long list of suppliers per package, with capacity, lead times and delivery slots for the target year.

2 Indicative prices into the floor price

Current supplier prices and dates feed the capex and the floor price, not last year's numbers.

3 Evidence the round can score

Delivery, resilience and sustainability evidence gathered once, for the round and later for lenders.

4 A draft package strategy

Packages, interfaces and the contracting approach sketched, so gate 1 opens with a draft, not a blank page.

What agents carry

- Supplier long lists and market notes, kept current.
- Questions to suppliers logged, so none is asked twice before and after award.
- Indicative prices and dates linked to the bid model.

What your people decide

- How much to spend before award, project by project.
- Which suppliers to engage, and on what terms.
- The capex and dates the bid rests on.

THE IGNIS VIEW

Early procurement often draws in people from technical, commercial and finance teams, and much of it is redone after award. Make it lighter and reusable, and the same development budget carries more projects to the round, with better evidence in each bid.

> Spend less to learn more before award. Then start gate 1 from what you already know.

03 PROCESS FIRST

Five pauses cost most teams the most time

So what: fix the process before you buy a tool. Find where each package waits, and why.

1 Offers that are not the same offer

Each bidder prices a slightly different scope, so the cheapest offer is often the one that left most out.

Fix: restate every offer onto one scope before anyone ranks it.

2 Questions asked and answered twice

Clarifications sit in email threads, and the same question comes back from each bidder.

Fix: one clarification log, answered once and shared.

3 A model that is not the contract

Price, indexation and caps move in negotiation; the financial model catches up later.

Fix: model and draft read the same terms, and a change needs an approval.

4 Dates that do not agree

The grid date, the CfD milestone and the supplier's programme live in three places.

Fix: one date register with one owner, checked at every gate.

5 The lender pack built at the end

Due diligence starts from a blank folder, months after the evidence was first gathered.

Fix: build the pack as you go, from the record.

Start with two

Pick the two pauses that cost you most, and find the reason for each. Fix those first. The rest can wait.

THE ORDER THAT WORKS

1 **Process first**

What do you run today? Map one package from strategy to signature. Remove steps that add nothing. Simplify what is left.

2 **Data second**

What does it run on? One record per project: scope, offers, terms, dates and evidence, versioned and owned.

3 **Agents third**

Then add the agents, on the redesigned process, with named people deciding at each gate.

Revisit the real problem first

Why does a tender take as long as it does? Which steps exist because a lender or a rule needs them, and which because "we have always done it"? Is the package split right for this market? Automate a broken process and you get a faster broken process.

04 COMPARING SUPPLIERS LIKE FOR LIKE

Ranking offers on different scopes is ranking scopes

So what: restate every offer onto one grid first. The real differences then show in days, not in the final week.

HOW A LIKE-FOR-LIKE GRID READS | A FRAMEWORK, NOT A REAL TENDER

Line	Supplier A	Supplier B	Supplier C	What the agent raises
Scope and interfaces	Same	Gap	Same	B leaves out one interface
Exclusions	Same	Same	Ask	C has not stated them
Programme against grid date	Same	Gap	Same	B misses the connection date
Price and indexation	Same	Ask	Same	Restated onto one index
Delay damages and caps	Same	Same	Gap	Below your last agreed position
Warranties and availability	Same	Same	Gap	Shorter term offered
Security and credit	Same	Excluded	Same	No parent guarantee
Resilience and supply chain	Same	Ask	Same	Evidence the bid and lenders need

Same: matches the tender scope. **Gap:** differs and changes the price. **Ask:** unclear, goes to the clarification log. **Excluded:** not offered.

What agents carry

- Read every offer and map it onto the grid.
- Flag gaps, exclusions and dates that miss the grid.
- Draft clarifications and log each answer once.
- Restate prices onto one index and one scope.

What your people decide

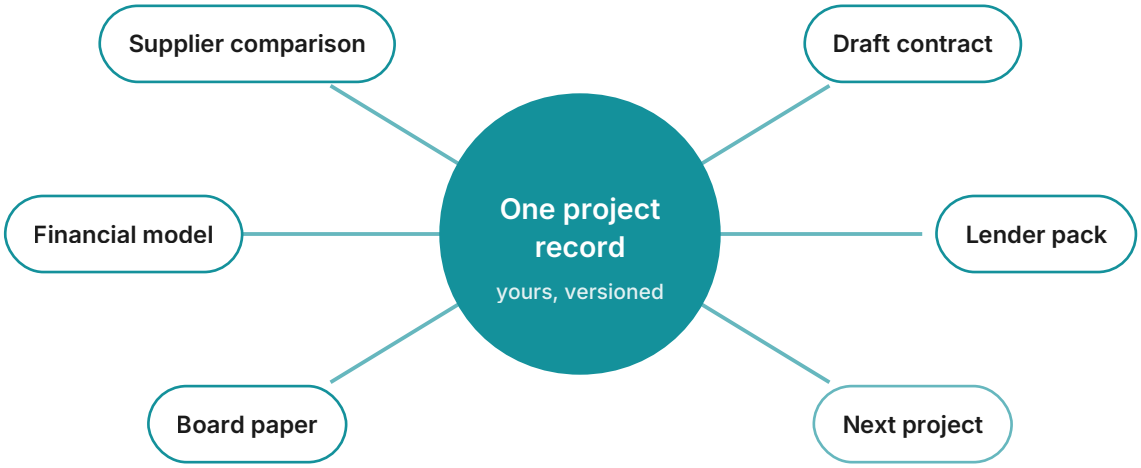
- Which gaps matter, and what they are worth.
- The shortlist and the preferred bidder.
- Where to push and where to concede.
- Supplier relationships and the final call.

Onshore and offshore: offshore runs fewer, larger packages with long supplier lists for each; onshore runs more, smaller packages, often several projects at once. The grid works for both, and the record keeps every past offer for the next tender.

04 CONTRACT AND LENDER PACK

When the contract, model and lender pack read one record, nothing drifts

So what: one record means a change in negotiation reaches the contract, model and lender pack at once, with a name and date.



What has to agree before signature

Item	Comparison	Contract	Model and lender pack
Scope	The restated scope	Scope of works	Capex and contingency
Price	Restated price	Contract price and indexation	Capex and cost case
Dates	Programme against grid	Key dates and delay damages	Schedule and milestone tests
Risk	Gaps and exclusions	Caps, warranties, security	Risk register and downside case

Approve changes, do not email them. A price, date or risk moves only with a named approval on the record. The consistency check runs before every gate.

Lenders ask the same questions. Keep every question and answer from the last close, and the next data room starts half built.

05 SAME TEAM, MORE OUTPUT

The same team, more output, better quality

So what: your people handle more packages and bidders, with fewer errors reaching a lender.

MORE

Quantity

- More packages run in parallel.
- More bidders assessed properly, not cut early for lack of time.
- The next gate ready on the day this one closes.

BETTER

Quality

- Every number traced to its source.
- Model, contract and pack in step.
- Terms won and conceded kept for the next project.

Who does what

Role	Agents carry	Your people keep
Head of procurement	Tender packs, the bidder log, the comparison grid	Package strategy, shortlist, supplier relationships
Commercial lead	First mark-up from your last agreed terms	Risk allocation and the negotiation
Finance and funding	Model updates, consistency checks, lender answers	The financing case and lender relationships
Technical lead	Interface and programme checks against the grid date	Design choices and technical sign-off
CEO and board	A board paper from the record, with the open risks	The investment decision and the signature

> People keep the judgement and the relationships. Agents carry the reading, the logs and the first drafts.



06 WHAT A GOVERNED SET-UP LOOKS LIKE

Your record, your gates, your environment

So what: three things decide whether any set-up helps. One record per project. Named people at each gate. An audit trail.

People and gates
Shortlist, preferred bidder, risk allocation, sign-off. Named people decide at each gate.

AI manager: plans the work, routes it to agents, checks it, brings each decision to a person

AGENTS

Tender pack Packages and scope drawn from the record	**Clarifications** Logged, routed and answered once	**Comparison** Every offer restated like for like
Mark-up First draft from the last agreed terms	**Consistency** Model, contract and pack agree	**Due diligence** Lender questions answered from the record

CONNECTORS TO THE TOOLS YOU ALREADY USE

Tender portal | Financial model | Document store | Data room | Email, calendar

Your data and context: one record, owned by you, that improves with every project

Project facts: scope, dates, grid, consents

Offers, clarifications and decisions

Past contracts: terms won and conceded

Lender questions and answers

Governance
Named gates
Audit trail
Access rules

Your environment

Source: Ignis framework, tool-agnostic.

Who runs the work

A coordinating agent breaks a goal such as "turbine supply to preferred bidder" into tasks, checks the output and stops at each gate for a decision by a named person.

The record is yours

Offers, terms, dates and lender answers stay in your environment under your access rules. Each project leaves it better for the next.

What stays human

The shortlist, the preferred bidder, risk allocation, the walk-away and the signature. Supplier and lender relationships.

Supplier prices stay confidential, and you can prove it

Decide where the models run and what they can read. Every read, change and approval should leave an audit trail you can show suppliers, partners and lenders.

Questions to ask any vendor

Does it work from our documents, cite its sources, stop at our gates, keep supplier prices in our environment, and let us leave with our data?

07 SELF-CHECK

How fast can your next package move?

So what: your score shows where to start. Tick what is true today, not what is planned.

- ☐ Package strategy starts before the round result, not after it
- ☐ We know where our pauses between gates are, and roughly how long each lasts
- ☐ Every offer is restated onto one scope before it is ranked
- ☐ Clarifications sit in one log, answered once and shared
- ☐ The grid date, the CfD milestone and supplier programmes sit in one date register
- ☐ The financial model reads the same terms as the draft contract
- ☐ A price, date or risk changes only with a named approval on the record
- ☐ The lender pack is built as we go, not at the end
- ☐ Terms won and conceded on the last contract are where the next one starts
- ☐ We have mapped one package end to end and know its two biggest pain points

Score: 0 to 3, start with the process map and a date register. 4 to 7, set up the comparison grid and the one record, then add agents. 8 to 10, you are ready to run more packages with the same team.

Work it out on your own numbers

For one project	Today	Redesigned	What it frees
Packages in procurement this year			
Days waiting between gates, in total			
Senior days per supplier comparison			
Lender questions answered from scratch			

08 THE COST OF DOING NOTHING

A pause between gates is rarely free

So what: two months of pauses cost a 60 MW project about £0.45m. A missed milestone puts the contract at risk.

Case	What happens	Value at stake today
Most likely	Two months lost to pauses between gates before commissioning	about £0.45m
Downside	A transformer slot is missed and the 18-month milestone slips; the contract is at risk	up to £39.9m
Hidden cost	Senior days spent restating offers and rebuilding the lender pack	[NOT IN RECORD]

60 MW solar example from page 2; Ignis calculation. No public dataset measures pauses between procurement gates, so the two months is an assumption to replace with your own.

Where you might disagree

Some pauses pay: a design freeze that prevents a change order, or a clarification round that exposes a gap. Wait on purpose, for a written reason.

What to do this month

1. Put the gate dates of one package you closed last year on one line, and name the two longest gaps.
2. Set up one date register for the grid date, the CfD milestone and supplier programmes.
3. Agree how much to spend on suppliers before award, per project.
4. Start one clarification log for the next tender.

HOW IGNIS HELPS

Ignis advises energy developers on procurement, from package strategy to financial close. We work from your documents, with your team. We map where one package waits, test the comparison and date register, and recommend what to fix first. Your team negotiates, allocates risk and signs.

Talk it through with Yorik

One question you can answer in one reply: which gate does your next package wait at longest today? Send it to **ignisleadership.com/contact** and we will come back with how other teams shorten that gap.

+ SOURCES AND METHOD

Sources

1. DESNZ, CfD Agreement, AR8 standard terms (Milestone Requirement: 18 months after the Agreement Date), published 2026. assets.publishing.service.gov.uk (AR8 CfD agreement documents)
2. NESO, "Understanding your offer and support available to you", connections reform, accessed 31 Oct 2026. neso.energy/industry-information/connections-reform/understanding-your-offer-and-support-available-you
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4. Vattenfall, "First six months 2023", 20 Jul 2023. group.vattenfall.com/press-and-media/newsroom/2023
5. Ørsted, company announcement "Ørsted to discontinue the Hornsea 4 offshore wind project in its current form", 7 May 2025. orsted.com/en/company-announcement-list/2025
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8. Rendaq, "AR8 standard timetable confirmed", 15 Oct 2026 (indicative sealed-bid and contract windows). rendaq.co.uk/insights/ar8-standard-timetable-confirmed
9. DESNZ, "Further reforms to the CfD scheme for AR7: government response", Jul 2025 (20-year CfD term). assets.publishing.service.gov.uk

Method and limits

Worked example. 60 MW × 8,760 hours × 11% capacity factor = 57,816 MWh a year. The 11% capacity factor, the 7% discount rate and the two months of pauses are Ignis assumptions, not sourced figures. Revenue uses the AR7 solar clearing price of £65.23/MWh in 2024 prices[7] as a proxy and ignores indexation, merchant tail and costs. Present value uses a 20-year annuity factor at 7% (10.594), matching the 20-year CfD term.[9] The downside shows the value of the whole contract at stake, not an expected loss.

Hornsea 4. Ørsted's reasons are paraphrased from its announcement; the exact wording could not be re-checked on 31 October 2026.

Frameworks. The gate flow, the comparison grid and the role table are Ignis views, free to use with your team. They are not data.

+ NEXT READS AND ABOUT IGNIS

ROUTE TO MARKET

Choose your route to market, then win it

AR8 bids are due by 9 December. Four questions find the anchor route for each project.

ALL STAGES

Agentic transformation for energy developers

Where agents help from early stage development to financial close, and where they do not.

MONTHLY

Market Monitor

The dates, prices and rules that moved this month. ignisleadership.com/resources

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About Ignis

Ignis Leadership is an advisory practice for energy developers across the UK and Europe, onshore and offshore. We help teams win the right to develop and move projects to financial close, with fewer delays, fewer surprises and stronger terms. Expert-led, AI-assisted, on your data.

About Yorik Tisseau

Founder of Ignis Leadership. 17 years closing commercial deals on energy infrastructure.

Talk it through with Yorik:
ignisleadership.com/contact



Process first. Data second. Agents third.

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